

Building a Unique Specialty Pharmacy Rotation

Daniel Jude, PharmD, AAHIVP, CSP, Travis Fransen, PharmD, MBA, Angela Wood, PharmD, BCSP, BCOP, CSP, Julia Rumley, PharmD



PURPOSE / BACKGROUND

- Residencies in specialty pharmacy are increasing across the United States as more health systems grow their specialty pharmacy services. Advanced Practice Pharmacy Experiences (APPEs) focused on building foundational specialty pharmacy skills are critical to foster interest in specialty pharmacy and improve the quality of specialty pharmacists.
- An innovative specialty pharmacy APPE was crafted and implemented at a health system in the Twin Cities Area of Minnesota.

OBJECTIVES

We review implementation, structure, student feedback measurements, and educational pearls from the 2020-2021 academic year

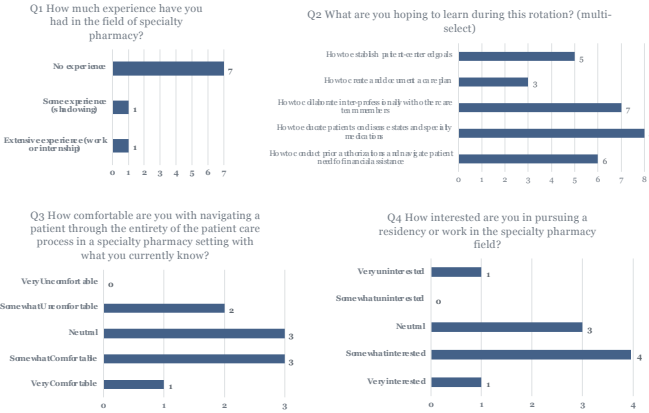
METHODS

- A Patient Care Elective format was utilized as the template for the experience due to the patient-oriented, clinical model of the specialty pharmacy program.
- Due to the SARS-CoV-2 pandemic, each rotation length was reduced to 4-weeks.
- Prior to or on their first day, all students except the first were sent a survey to assist with determining background knowledge of specialty pharmacy and their goals for the rotation.
- Onboarding occurred the first week, including review of general specialty pharmacy topics: definition of specialty medications, specialty pharmacy business models, reimbursement, limited-distribution drugs, payer access, clinical program structures, accreditation, safety and adverse event reporting.
- To ensure appropriate representation of specialty pharmacy disease states, the students spent time at different specialty pharmacy practice sites with different specialty pharmacy preceptors for at least 1-week intervals with weekly deliverables (table 1).
- Weekly deliverables were presented at "Feedback Friday" time slots on Fridays at 12-noon via webinar format to all preceptors as schedules allowed. Preceptors asked questions and assigned follow up items to reinforce concepts and clinical skills.
- Day-to-day clinical tasks included answering clinical questions, chart review, assessing patient status, preparing patient communications, collecting laboratory and objective data, reviewing appropriateness of specialty pharmacotherapy.

Table 1	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Clinic Location	Infectious Disease	Oncology	General Specialty	General Specialty
Disease States Included	HIV, HCV, HBV, LTBI, antifungals	Oral oncolytics, hematology	Cardio, MS, Rheum, Derm, GI, Endo, HAE, ALS, Others	Cardio, MS, Rheum, Derm, GI, Endo, HAE, ALS, Others
Deliverables	Journal Club Semiformal Patient Case Presentation	Journal Club Semiformal Patient Case Presentation	Journal Club Semiformal Patient Case Presentation	Journal Club Formal Patient Care Presentation

RESULTS

Student Pre-Rotation Survey (n=9)



STUDENT COMMENTS

- "This rotation... was very unique and much different from my other rotation. I have learned a lot more about the treatment and medication management of patient with uncommon health conditions, especially HIV. It was challenging, given that a journal club and patient case presentations was expected every week about antiretroviral therapy, rheumatology, oncology, and cardiology, while learning from knowledgeable pharmacists in each category."
- "I appreciated the challenge of doing a journal club and patient case presentation every week. I enjoyed being able to relate the two weekly projects and really dig into a topic. I also really liked that I was able to split time between the different specialty areas, I think that was really helpful to see how each are different but also related as a whole."
- "... I wish I had this experience sooner as I have grown in my interest in specialty pharmacy and may want to pursue a career in it someday..."
- "Each day felt very productive, and my interest in specialty pharmacist developed throughout the experience, which I can credit to the enthusiasm with which [the preceptors] tackled their responsibilities both as a pharmacist and as an educator. I would recommend this rotation site to any of my peers regardless of their interest in specialty pharmacy."
- "I really appreciated [the preceptors] relating this experience to my interest in managed care as much as possible. I also enjoyed being able to complete a journal club weekly so I could apply feedback from previous weeks and get more practice."

RESULTS

Student Evaluations (n=10)	Site Average	All Other Site Avg.
1. The preceptor is interested in teaching this rotation.	5.00	4.71
2. The preceptor related to me as individual.	5.00	4.64
3. The preceptor encouraged me to actively participate in discussion and problem solving exercises.	5.00	4.70
4. I had adequate patient or guardian contact on this rotation to meet the learning objectives.	4.90	4.58
5. I had access to necessary patient information.	5.00	4.70
6. I was encouraged to access and use resource materials.	5.00	4.77
7. I had access to all necessary reference material, either hard copy or via electronic means.	5.00	4.75
8. The preceptor described their approach to thinking about therapeutic problems.	4.90	4.61
9. The preceptor is readily available to answer questions and concerns.	5.00	4.69
10. The preceptor provided good direction and feedback.	4.90	4.64
11. The preceptor is knowledgeable in his/her response to questions regarding his/her approach to therapy.	5.00	4.76
12. The preceptor evaluated me around the midpoint of the rotation.	4.80	4.53
13. The preceptor evaluated me at the end of the rotation that was in a manner which was helpful to me.	4.80	4.64
14. The preceptor served as a role model for pharmacist practicing in this practice setting.	4.90	4.74
15. The rotation provided opportunities to interact with other health care professionals.	4.50	4.52
16. The goals and objectives of the rotation were outlined and/or explained at the beginning of the rotation.	4.90	4.55
17. Rotation activities were well organized and structured.	4.70	4.43
18. This rotation provided an environment (physical and philosophical) that facilitated my learning.	4.90	4.59
19. Others at the rotation site were receptive and willing to interact with me.	4.80	4.72
20. My verbal communication skills were enhanced on this rotation.	4.90	4.58
21. My written communication skills or documentation skills were enhanced on this rotation.	4.90	4.58
22. My clinical skills were enhanced on this rotation.	4.90	4.66
23. I was able to apply previously learned materials on this rotation.	4.90	4.66
24. I believe this experience will help me be a better pharmacist.	5.00	4.73

Score Legend	Value
1.00	Strongly Disagree
2.00	Disagree
3.00	Neutral
4.00	Agree
5.00	Strongly Agree

- Students reported discussing patient care or practice related issues >3 hours daily
- The precepting pharmacists appreciated the balance of sharing student oversight and participating in clinical discussion of other specialties
- Formal presentations were utilized to promote residency-consideration and provide presentations for residency interviews
- Structured discussions were appreciated the most by students and eased time-burden on preceptors
- Choosing same high-value articles for journal clubs for each rotation promoted consistent learning
- Career goals were consistently made the focal point of all clinical discussions.

Ten students completed the experience; all 10 rated the APPE overall with top score "Excellent"

CONCLUSIONS

- Overall student feedback was overwhelmingly positive, with only one item slightly below all other site's average. This reflects the difficulty in having students collaborate with providers rotating quickly through specialty clinics.
- Few students had specialty experience coming into the rotation, but many expressed strong engagement in the challenging environment.
- A patient care APPE was incredibly successful in the health system-based specialty pharmacy setting. All health systems that have a specialty pharmacy program should consider developing a similar program to help foster interest in specialty pharmacy as well as sharpen clinical acumens.